

CORE FORMULA

We got interrupted. You were saying [the specific thread]. Want to pick that back up? -> Minimum: "You were saying [X] - want to continue?" -> High-care: "We got interrupted right as you got to [X]. I do not want to lose that if it still feels useful - want to come back to it?" -> Group: "Before we moved on, [Name] was making a point about [X]. [Name], do you want to finish that?" -> Release: "Or we can leave it there if the moment has passed."

MINIMUM VIABLE MOVE

You were saying [X] before we got interrupted - want to pick that back up?

BEST FOR

- One-to-one conversations interrupted by a person, device, or practical task.
- Meetings where a speaker was cut off or overshadowed.
- Emotionally meaningful stories that paused unexpectedly.
- Calls or video meetings that dropped or froze.
- Group discussions where a quieter person lost the floor.
- Customer or support conversations where continuity matters.
- Social moments where someone was mid-thought and does not want to fight for airtime.

PHRASE BANK

Quick bridges · Short one-line re-entries

- "You were saying - want to pick that back up?"
- "We got pulled away. Carry on from where you were?"
- "You were mid-thought. Go on."
- "You had the floor before that - finish it?"
- "Back to you - you were partway through."
- "Sorry, the thread broke there. You were saying?"
- "You were about to get to the good bit. Keep going?"

Social / everyday · Warm re-entry with a friend

- "You were telling me about your weekend before we got interrupted - want to keep going?"
- "I want to come back to what you were saying about your sister. What happened next?"
- "We got pulled off track. You were saying the trip felt different this time."
- "I remember you were about to say why that mattered. Want to pick it back up?"
- "You were at the part where the train got delayed - what happened next?"
- "Sorry, we got cut off - you were telling me how it went with your mum."

Meetings / work · Returning to a work thread

- "Before we were interrupted, you were outlining the risk around timing. Please carry on."
- "Coming back to your earlier point about the handover - what was the main concern?"
- "The thread before the interruption was budget ownership. Should we resume there?"
- "The open question before the tangent was whether the handover owner is clear."
- "Let's restore the thread - you were making the case that the rollout risk is mostly timing."
- "Thanks for waiting. You were explaining the invoice error started after the plan change - is that right?"

Calls, video & messages · Remote and digital re-entry

- "The call froze right as you were explaining the customer issue. Could you continue from there?"

- "We lost audio after 'the main blocker is...'. What was the blocker?"
- "Picking up from your last message: you said the tone felt off. What part felt off?"
- "Threading this back - before the side chat, you asked about the timeline."
- "The line dropped right after you said the deadline depends on legal review. Can you pick up there?"

Firm under pressure · Restoring the thread when time is tight

- "We need to keep moving, but I do not want to lose that point. Give us the short version."
- "Let's pause the tangent. You were making the decision risk clear - finish that in one minute."
- "I am going to restore the thread: the interruption came during the escalation point. Continue from there."
- "One quick thing before we move on - you had not finished the point about ownership."
- "Hold the tangent a second. You were partway through the actual risk - go on."

Protecting a quieter voice · Handing the floor back in a group

- "I want to make sure we do not lose Priya's point. Priya, you were on the dependency issue."
- "Before we moved on, Maya was making a point about the rollout. Maya, do you want to finish that?"
- "Jordan had the floor before the tangent. Jordan, you were saying the risk was mostly timing?"
- "We got interrupted during something personal. No pressure to keep going, but I am still here if you want to."
- "That got cut off, and I do not want it lost. You were saying the week has felt heavy."
- "Let's give Sam the floor back - you were explaining the data-quality risk."

Softening & release · Low-pressure exits

- "No need to continue if the moment has passed."
- "We can park it if it no longer feels relevant."
- "Only if you still want to go there."
- "If it feels better to leave it, that is fine too."
- "No pressure - I just did not want to lose it."
- "We can leave it if that was enough."
- "All good - we can leave it there."

WEAK -> BETTER -> BEST

- Weak: "Anyway, what were you saying?"
Better: "You were talking about the dinner thing."
Best: "We got interrupted right as you said the dinner got awkward. Want to tell me what happened?"
- Weak: "Let's get back on track."
Better: "Sam had a point before we shifted."
Best: "Before the fire drill, Sam was explaining the data-quality risk. Sam, do you want to finish that thought?"
- Weak: "Sorry, continue."
Better: "The call dropped when you were talking about the deadline."
Best: "The call dropped right after you said the deadline depends on legal review. Can you pick up there?"
- Weak: "So, back to your problem."
Better: "You were saying this has been difficult."
Best: "We got interrupted during something personal. No pressure to continue, but I remember you were saying the week has felt heavy."

DECISION TREE

If The thread broke, but is the topic still safe and appropriate to reopen?

If it was personal or exposing, do not reopen it in the room - offer it later or let it go.
"That might be better one-on-one - can we pick it up after?"

If Can you name the last meaningful thread?

If yes, lead with a specific anchor. If not, offer a humble bridge and let them choose the re-entry point.
"We got interrupted and I have half-lost the thread - what would you like to come back to?"

If Does the person still have energy for the topic?

Clear energy - invite re-entry. Unclear - add a release clause. Gone - let it go.

"You were saying the timeline felt tight - want to finish that, or leave it?"

If Are you in a group?

Protect the person who lost the floor by naming them and their point; solo, use a direct personal bridge.

"Priya, you were on the dependency issue - do you want to finish?"

If Did the re-entry land?

If they re-engage, listen and do not overtalk. If not, recover and release without pressure.

"No need to continue - I just did not want to lose it."

If Is the topic now serving you more than them?

If continuing is really your agenda, stop - restoring a thread is not agenda control.

"All good - we can leave it there."

SCENARIOS

Friend interrupted mid-story

Restore the last vivid point and let them run with it. — "You were at the part where the train got delayed - what happened next?"

A speaker was cut off in a meeting

Return the floor publicly, naming them and their point, without blaming the interrupter. — "I do not want to lose Jordan's risk point. Jordan, do you want to finish?"

The call or video dropped

Quote the last phrase you heard so they do not restart from scratch. — "I lost you after 'the main constraint is procurement.' Can you pick up there?"

A sensitive disclosure got interrupted

Protect safety before content - offer, then release fast if they hesitate. — "We got interrupted during something personal. No pressure, but I am still here if you want to."

Customer interrupted by a hold or transfer

Signal continuity and take the reconstruction off their plate. — "Thanks for waiting. You were explaining the invoice error started after the plan change - is that right?"

WHEN NOT TO USE

- Physical safety or an immediate emergency takes priority.
- The other person clearly changed the subject to protect themselves.
- The interruption revealed a higher priority or a genuine emergency.
- The topic was unsafe, intrusive, or too personal to reopen.
- They have already declined to continue.
- The break was long enough that the context has genuinely changed.
- Re-entry would embarrass someone in a group.
- You only want to return because the topic benefits you.

7-DAY PRACTICE DRILL

Day 1 — Spot the break

Through one day, notice every time a conversation you are in gets interrupted - phone, walk-in, tangent, dropped call. Just count them; do not act yet. The skill starts with perceiving the break.

Day 2 — Catch the anchor

Listen to a 60-second story, then interrupt yourself with a neutral task for ten seconds. Re-enter by naming the last meaningful noun or concern. Score: did your phrase include it?

Day 3 — Name it neutrally

Practise the break line ten times using 'We got interrupted', never 'You got interrupted'. Notice how the neutral, blame-free framing lands softer.

Day 4 — Add the invitation

Take five real threads and write each as "You were saying ____ - want to pick that back up?" Say them aloud until they sound natural rather than scripted.

Day 5 — Add a release clause

Rewrite yesterday's five with a low-pressure exit: '...only if it still feels useful' or '...or we can leave it there.' Use one in a real conversation.

Day 6 — Protect a floor

In a group or meeting, when someone loses the floor, re-enter by naming the speaker and their point - not by scolding the interrupter. "Maya, you were saying..."

Day 7 — Recover a miss

Deliberately pick the wrong anchor once, then practise the recovery: "I may have picked up the wrong thread - where should we restart?" Score each re-entry 0-2 (0 = no anchor or too much pressure; 2 = clear anchor plus low-pressure invitation).

AFTER-ACTION CHECKLIST

- Did I name the interruption neutrally - 'we', not 'you'?
- Did I return to their thread, not just my agenda?
- Did I use a specific anchor rather than 'where were we?'
- Did I invite rather than demand continuation?
- Did I add a release clause when the topic was personal or uncertain?
- Did I stop the moment they declined?